Building Confidence, Shape, Passing and 1–2s

Session Purpose

This session is designed as a positive reset after a match where the team won but played below its usual standard.

The aim is not to focus on mistakes. The aim is to rebuild confidence and reinforce the habits that make the team play well:

- Good first touch.
- Simple, accurate passing.
- Good attacking and defensive shape.
- Quick reaction when possession changes.
- Using 1–2s to play around opponents.
- Moving after passing rather than standing still.

Session length: 60 minutes

Core Team Messages

Before starting the practical work, explain the following principles clearly and briefly.

1. What Is a Good First Touch?

A good first touch should make the next action easier.

The first touch should:

- Bring the ball under control.
- Move it slightly away from pressure where possible.
- Set up the next pass.
- Allow the player to get their head up.
- Avoid trapping the ball awkwardly underneath the feet.

Coaching Cue

> **First touch sets up the second.**

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2. What Does a Simple Pass Look Like?

A simple pass is the easiest effective option.

It should:

- Go to a teammate who is clearly available.
- Be played with enough pace to arrive cleanly.
- Go to feet or slightly into the teammate's path.
- Help the receiving player make their next action.
- Keep possession rather than force a difficult forward ball.

Backward and sideways passes are good passes if they help the team keep possession and find a better opening.

Coaching Cue

> **See it – play it – move.**

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3. What Is Our Shape?

Our shape changes depending on who has possession.

When We Have the Ball

Make the pitch bigger.

Players should:

- Spread out.
- Give width.
- Give the player on the ball more than one option.
- Provide options ahead, beside and behind.
- Avoid everyone moving towards the ball.

When We Do Not Have the Ball

Make the pitch smaller.

Players should:

- Recover into a compact shape.
- Protect the middle.
- Stay connected to teammates.
- Avoid being dragged all over the pitch.
- Pick up opponents within their area.

Coaching Cue

> **Ball ours – get big.**
> **Ball theirs – get small.**

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4. Transition – When Possession Changes

The moment possession changes, everybody should react.

When We Win the Ball

- Secure the ball first.
- Give the player on the ball immediate support.
- Spread out quickly.
- Create forward, sideways and backward passing options.

Coaching Cue

> **Secure it – support it – spread out.**

When We Lose the Ball

- Nearest player delays the opponent.
- Everyone else recovers quickly.
- Protect the middle.
- Get compact before chasing.

Coaching Cue

> **Delay – recover – get small.**

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5. Using 1–2s

A 1–2 is one of the simplest ways to get around an opponent.

The habit should be:

Pass → move immediately → receive beyond the defender.

The player making the first pass should not stand still.

The supporting player should expect the return pass and play it quickly when it is available.

Coaching Cue

> **Pass and go – don't pass and watch.**

Session Plan

1. Confidence Passing Warm-Up

Duration: 10 minutes

Players work in pairs approximately 5–7 metres apart.

Start with simple two-touch passing.

The receiving player should:

1. Take a controlled first touch.
2. Get the ball out of their feet.
3. Look up.
4. Play a firm, accurate return pass.

Progress by:

- Increasing the distance slightly.
- Asking players to receive across the body.
- Moving a step or two after each pass.
- Passing to the receiver's left or right foot.

Do not make the drill difficult too early.

The purpose is to give players lots of successful touches and passes.

Coaching Points

- First touch prepares the pass.
- Get your head up.
- Pass firmly enough.
- Help the receiving player.
- Move after passing.

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2. Pass, Move and Support Triangles

Duration: 10 minutes

Work in groups of three.

Set up a triangle approximately 6–8 metres between players.

Players pass around the triangle.

After passing, the player moves to a new supporting position.

Progress to:

- Pass and follow.
- Receive on the back foot.
- Change direction.
- Play with two touches where possible.

The emphasis is not speed for its own sake.

The emphasis is:

Good first touch → simple pass → immediate movement.

Coaching Cue

> **Pass – move – give an option.**

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3. 1–2 Combination Drill

Duration: 10 minutes

Set up groups of three:

- Player A with the ball.
- Player B as support.
- Player C as a passive defender.

Player A passes to Player B and immediately moves around Player C.

Player B returns the pass into Player A's path.

Rotate roles regularly.

Progression 1

Defender remains passive.

Focus on the timing of the movement and return pass.

Progression 2

Defender becomes semi-active.

They may block one route but should not fully compete.

Progression 3

Defender becomes active.

The attacking pair must decide whether the 1–2 is available.

If it is not available, they should keep possession rather than force it.

Coaching Points

- Pass and move immediately.
- Do not move too close to the defender.
- Supporting player should expect the return pass.
- Return pass should go into the runner's path.
- Do not force a 1–2 if the defender has read it.

Coaching Cue

> **Pass and go – don't pass and watch.**

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4. Possession Game – Make the Pitch Big

Duration: 10 minutes

Play 4v2 or 5v2 in a generous area.

The possession team aims to keep the ball.

Award one point for five consecutive passes.

Award an additional point if the sequence includes a successful 1–2.

Encourage:

- Good first touch.
- Simple passing.
- Support after the pass.
- Moving away from the ball to create space.
- Using the whole area.

If possession is lost, the team that lost the ball should react immediately.

Coaching Questions

- Where is the easiest pass?
- Can you give the player on the ball another option?
- Have you moved after passing?
- Can a 1–2 take an opponent out of the game?

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5. Transition and Shape Game

Duration: 10 minutes

Play a small-sided game such as 4v4 or 5v5.

The main focus is the change in shape when possession changes.

When a Team Wins Possession

They should:

- Secure the ball.
- Spread out.
- Give width.
- Create forward, sideways and backward options.

When a Team Loses Possession

They should:

- Delay the ball.
- Recover quickly.
- Get compact.
- Protect the middle.

Pause the game occasionally and ask:

> **Whose ball is it?**

Then ask:

> **Should we be big or small?**

Allow players to correct their own positions before restarting.

Coaching Cue

> **Ball ours – get big.**
> **Ball theirs – get small.**

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6. Conditioned Game

Duration: 5 minutes

Play normal walking football but reward the behaviours being coached.

Suggested scoring:

- Normal goal = 1 point.
- Goal following a successful 1–2 = 2 points.
- Goal following a sequence of four or more passes = 2 points.

Do not overload the game with too many rules.

The aim is to encourage good habits rather than make the game artificial.

Look for:

- Good first touch.
- Simple passes.
- Movement after passing.
- 1–2s.
- Width in possession.
- Compactness out of possession.
- Quick reaction to transition.

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7. Free Game

Duration: 5 minutes

Remove the conditions.

Play normal walking football.

Avoid constant coaching.

Observe whether the habits from the session appear naturally.

Before starting, remind the players of the key messages:

> **First touch sets up the second.**
>
> **See it – play it – move.**
>
> **Pass and go – don't pass and watch.**
>
> **Ball ours – get big. Ball theirs – get small.**

Coaching Approach

This should be a positive session.

Praise the behaviours you want to see.

Examples:

- "Good first touch."
- "Great simple pass."
- "Good movement after the pass."
- "Excellent support angle."
- "That's a good 1–2."
- "Great reaction when we lost it."
- "Good shape."
- "That's exactly the right backward pass."

Avoid judging success only by goals or tackles.

Good football may simply be:

Control → pass → move → support → keep possession

Good defending may simply be:

Delay → recover → compact shape → force the ball backwards

Main Session Message

The team does not need to do anything complicated to play well.

The key habits are:

First touch → simple pass → move → support → use 1–2s → make the pitch big

When possession is lost:

React → delay → recover → get compact

The overall message for the players is:

> **Do the simple things well, and the game becomes easier.**